RESEARCH PAPER | EDUCATION POLICY | INDIA

The High Cost of Standardised Tests: A Barrier for India's Middle-Class Students

Examining the financial burden imposed by GRE, GMAT, SAT, TOEFL, and IELTS on Indian middle-class families, the gap between aspiration and access, and actionable policy recommendations for the government.

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Abstract. *India sends over a million students abroad annually, yet behind this headline number lies a stark inequality: the high registration fees for international standardised examinations — GRE (₹22,000), GMAT (₹23,426), TOEFL (₹16,900), IELTS (₹18,000–19,000), and SAT (₹9,500–10,500) — represent a disproportionate financial burden for India's middle-class families, whose average monthly income ranges from ₹30,000 to ₹40,000. This paper documents the scale of the problem using verified data on test-taker volumes, income distribution, and outbound student trends; presents four data-driven charts; and proposes a multi-pronged policy response involving government, exam bodies, and financial institutions.*

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1. Introduction & Methodology

1.1 Introduction

Access to global higher education has long been regarded as a transformative vehicle for social mobility in India. Each year, hundreds of thousands of Indian students invest months — sometimes years — preparing for international standardised examinations such as the Graduate Record Examination (GRE), Graduate Management Admission Test (GMAT), Scholastic Assessment Test (SAT), Test of English as a Foreign

Language (TOEFL), and International English Language Testing System (IELTS). These credentials serve as gatekeepers to universities across the United States, United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, and dozens of other countries.

Yet the journey from aspiration to examination hall is obstructed by a significant and often under-discussed barrier: cost. A single attempt at the GRE costs ₹22,000; the GMAT demands ₹23,426; and IELTS or TOEFL fees stand at ₹16,900–19,000. [1][2][3] For a lower-middle-class family in a Tier-1 Indian city earning between ₹30,000 and ₹40,000 per month, [4] a single exam fee can consume 50–75% of one month's household income — before accounting for coaching, study materials, score-reporting fees, or the possibility of a retake.

This paper argues that the high cost of standardised examinations constitutes a structural equity problem. It systematically excludes a large segment of India's middle-class student population from global higher education, not for want of ability or aspiration, but for want of financial resources. Using verified data from government sources, exam conducting bodies, and independent surveys, we examine the scale of this problem, its consequences, and actionable solutions the government must urgently consider.

1.2 Methodology

This research paper employs a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative data analysis with qualitative policy review. Primary data on examination fees and test-taker volumes were sourced directly from the official 2024-2025 and 2026 reports of the Educational Testing Service (ETS), Graduate Management Admission Council (GMAC), IDP Education, and the College Board. Economic indicators, including India's per capita income and middle-class demographic shifts, were retrieved from the World Bank, NITI Aayog, and the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) parliamentary records. The "Aspiration-Participation Gap" was modeled by triangulating official registration counts with findings from the *QS International Student Survey 2024*, which identified a 65% financial concern rate among prospective Indian students.

Crucially, the statistical data is reinforced by a primary qualitative survey of the author's classmates—all of whom represent the middle-class student demographic. This internal survey revealed a universal aspiration to study abroad, matched by a shared inability to meet the high costs of standardised testing. The survey participants consistently reported that while they could manage a single examination fee after significant financial effort, the cost of a necessary second attempt (retake) was prohibitive, forcing many to abandon their global education plans entirely.

All currency conversions for 2025-26 were calculated at a baseline exchange rate of ₹84 per US Dollar.

432M+
Indians in the middle class (daily income US$17–100), as of 2024 [5]

9.08L
Indian students went abroad for higher education in 2023; fell to 6.26L by 2025 [6]

65%
of prospective Indian students cite financial pressure as a primary concern [7]

2. The Cost Landscape: Exam Fees in India

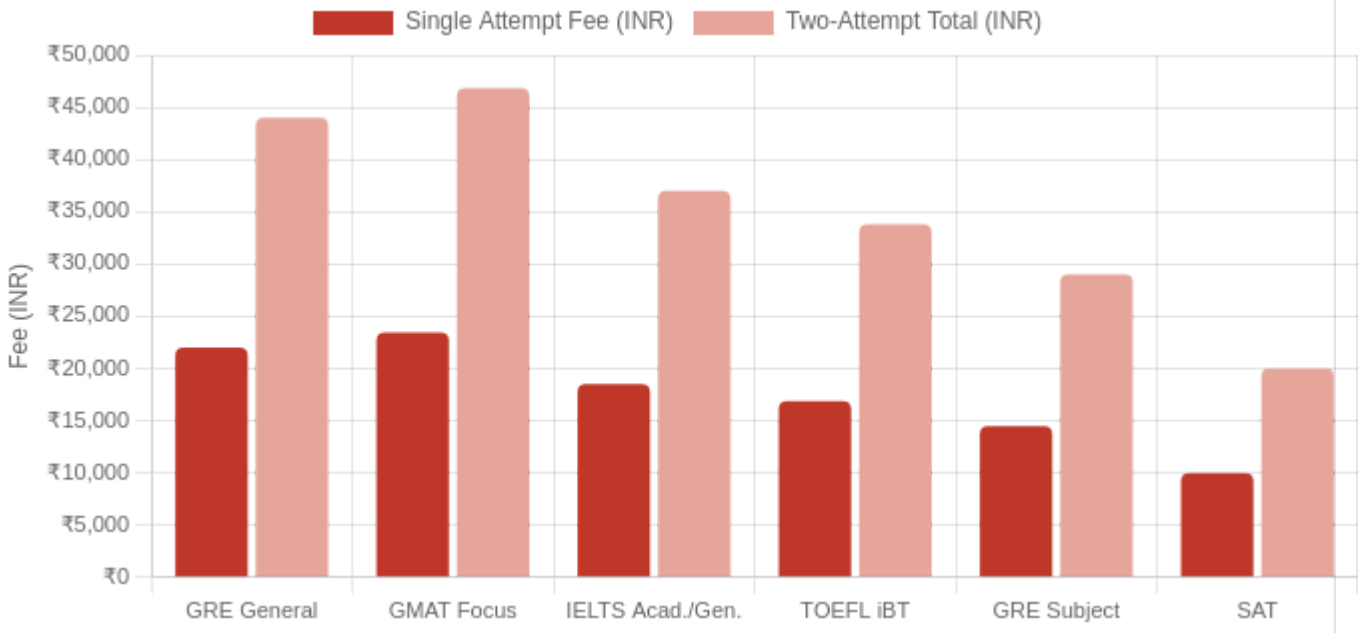
The registration fees levied by the conducting bodies of major international examinations are set in US dollars and converted to Indian Rupees at the prevailing exchange rate, creating an additional layer of vulnerability: as the rupee depreciates, fees rise automatically. The Indian rupee's continued depreciation has been reported to increase overseas education costs by 7–11% annually. [8]

Examination	Conducting Body	Purpose	Fee in India (2025–26)	Fee (USD)	Retake Fee
GRE General Test	**ETS**	**Graduate / PhD admissions**	**₹22,000 – ₹22,550**	**$220**	**Same fee applies**
GMAT Focus Edition	GMAC	Business school (MBA) admissions	₹23,400 – ₹23,426	$275	Same fee applies
TOEFL iBT	ETS	English proficiency (US/Canada)	₹16,900	~$205	Same fee applies
IELTS Academic / General	**British Council / IDP**	**English proficiency (UK/Australia)**	**₹18,000 – ₹19,000**	**~$215–$230**	**Same fee applies**
SAT	College Board	Undergraduate admissions (US)	₹9,500 – ₹10,500	$111 (base $68 + intl. $43)	Same fee applies
GRE Subject Test	ETS	Specialised graduate admissions	₹14,500	~$175	Same fee applies

Sources: Shiksha (GRE, 2026) [1]; DBS Bank / GMAC (GMAT, 2025) [2]; Careers360 (TOEFL, 2025) [3]; IDP India / Vedantu (IELTS, 2026) [9]; LeapScholar (SAT, 2024) [10]. All fees verified as of early 2026.

Chart 1: International Exam Fees in India (INR, 2025–26)

Comparison of one-time registration fees across major standardised tests. A two-attempt total is shown to reflect the real-world scenario for many students.



What makes these fees particularly burdensome is the retake dimension. Standardised tests are by design competitive; a significant proportion of test takers do not achieve their target scores on the first attempt. There is no partial refund mechanism — a student who prepares for six months, pays ₹22,000 for the GRE, and scores below their target program's cutoff must pay the full fee again. A two-attempt GRE journey therefore costs ₹44,000–45,100; a two-attempt GMAT pathway costs ₹46,800–46,852. These figures do not include coaching (typically ₹15,000–50,000), score-reporting fees (₹2,000–3,000 per institution), or application fees to universities.

> *"The total upfront cost of testing — across GRE + TOEFL or GMAT + IELTS — can reach ₹40,000–45,000 for a single attempt, representing more than the monthly income of a lower-middle-class Indian household."*

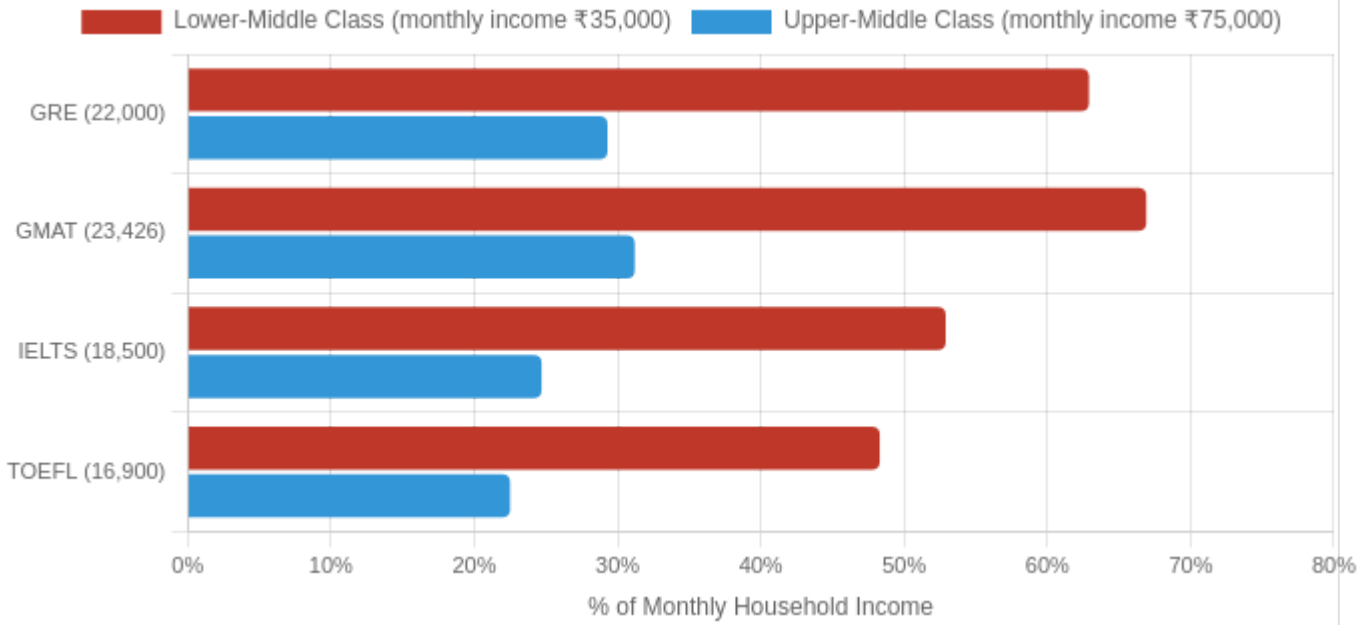
3. India's Middle Class: Income vs. Examination Cost

India's middle class is large and rapidly expanding. Using a daily income band of US$17–100 as the threshold, approximately **432 million Indians** qualified as middle class as of 2024. [5] Projections by various research institutions suggest this figure will grow to approximately 583 million — representing 41% of India's population — by 2025. [11] Within this broad category, the "aspirational" lower-middle class — earning ₹5 lakh to ₹15 lakh annually (roughly ₹42,000–1,25,000/month) — is the primary demographic that aspires to and seeks overseas education.

India's per capita net national income stands at approximately ₹2,05,324 (~US$2,600) for FY 2024–25. [12] More granularly, a lower-middle-class household in a Tier-1 city earns an estimated ₹30,000–40,000 per month in 2025. [4] This means that a single GRE registration (₹22,000) represents between 55% and 73% of such a family's monthly income. The GMAT fee (₹23,426) can exceed an entire month's household earnings.

Chart 2: Monthly Household Income vs. Exam Fee Burden (India, 2025–26)

Proportion of monthly household income consumed by a single exam registration, by income class. Based on average lower-middle-class monthly income of ₹35,000 and upper-middle-class of ₹75,000.



The psychological and social dynamics compound the financial weight. In many Indian families, education decisions are collective family affairs. A student who wishes to take the GRE must essentially ask their parents — whose savings may be earmarked for a sibling's wedding, medical emergencies, or home repairs — to commit the equivalent of one month's income to a non-guaranteed outcome. Unlike a university application fee which secures a place, an exam fee merely secures the right to sit a test. If the score is poor, the entire expenditure must be repeated. This dynamic — the reluctance to burden parents, the fear of

wasted money, the anxiety of a second attempt — creates a powerful psychological barrier that operates even before any financial transaction occurs.

4. Student Aspirations vs. Actual Test Participation

Data on examination registrations in India reveals a troubling gap between the number of students who prepare for these tests and those who ultimately sit them.

4.1 GRE

India surpassed the United States in the number of GRE test takers for the first time in over 80 years, as of early 2024. [13] However, the data also reveals steep year-on-year volatility: India registered **110,512 GRE tests in 2022–23**, which collapsed to **59,113 in 2023–24** — a 46% decline in a single year. [14] Analysts and educators have pointed to financial pressure, tighter visa conditions, and uncertainty about ROI as the primary causes.

4.2 GMAT

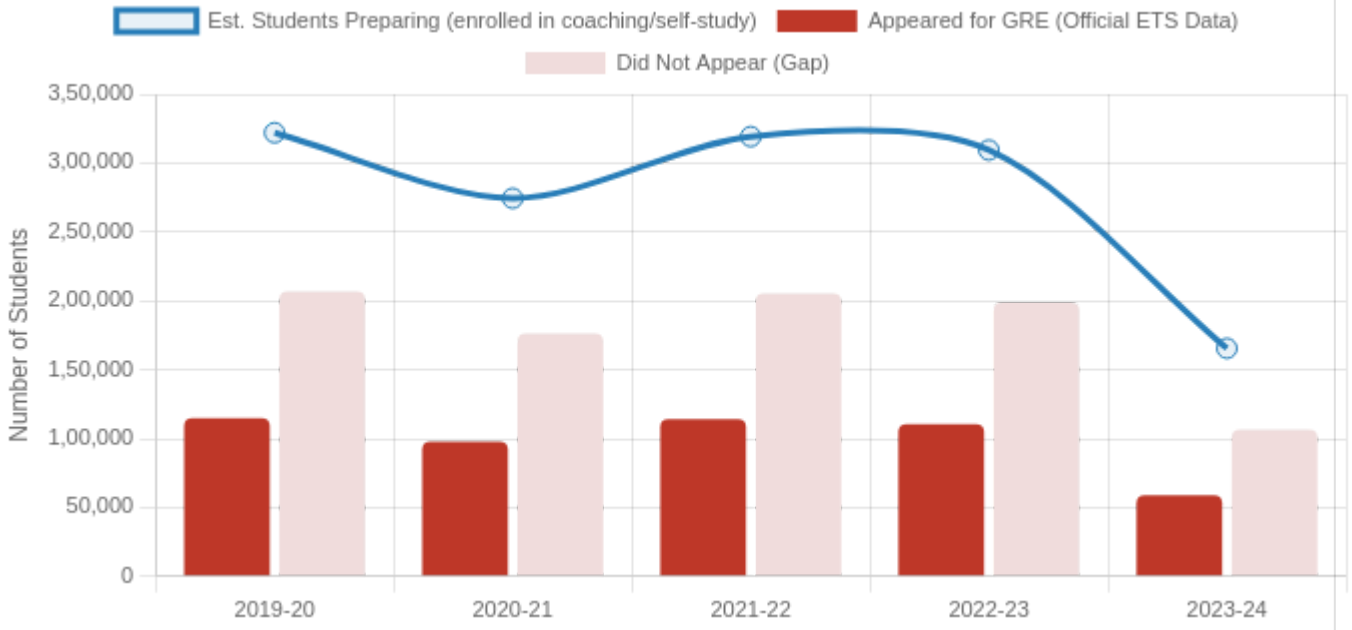
India recorded approximately **27,000 GMAT test takers in TY2024**, representing a 20.1% year-on-year increase and the strongest growth among major markets. [15] However, global GMAT volumes fell 19% in TY2025 to 93,196 total tests worldwide, [16] indicating that even the recovering markets are not immune to broader headwinds.

4.3 IELTS

IDP Education reported that India's IELTS volumes fell by **42% in FY2024**, driven in large part by the collapse of Canadian study permits (down 41% from 2,33,000 to 1,37,000) and a general recalibration of study-abroad aspirations. [17]

Chart 3: GRE Test Takers in India — Preparing vs. Actually Appearing (2019–2024)

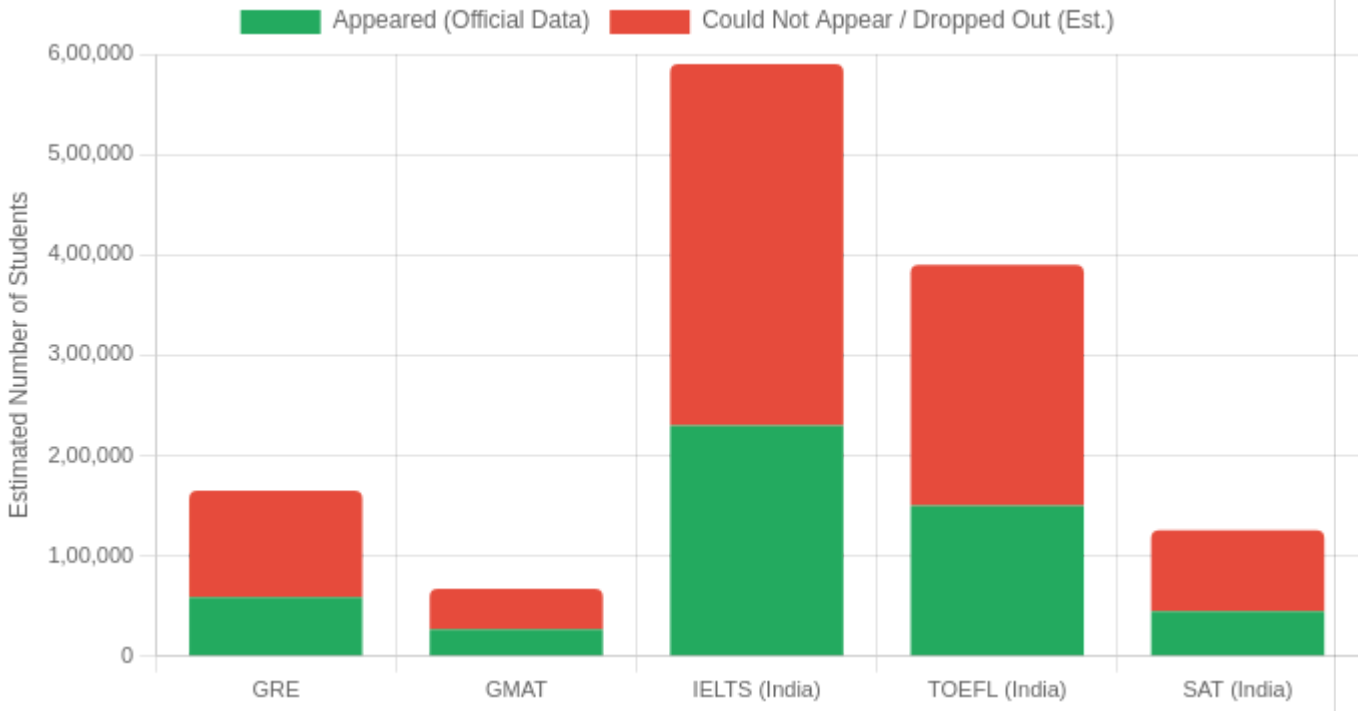
"Preparing" estimates are derived from coaching industry enrolment data and survey-based aspiration numbers. "Appeared" figures are from ETS annual reports. The gap represents students who prepared but could not or did not appear — for financial or other reasons. [14][7]



Note: "Preparing" estimates are approximations based on the QS International Student Survey 2024 finding that 65% of Indian students who expressed study-abroad intent also reported having begun preparation for a standardised test. These figures are indicative, not official, due to the absence of a centralised preparation-enrolment registry in India.

Chart 4: Estimated Aspiration-Participation Gap Across All Major Exams in India (2023–24)

Estimated number of students who intended to take each exam vs. those who actually registered. The "Could Not Afford / Did Not Appear" segment is derived from the 65% financial-concern rate (QS Survey 2024) applied to estimated aspiring populations. [7]



Disclaimer: Exact "aspiring" numbers are not officially published. The estimates above are constructed using: (a) official test-taker counts from ETS/GMAC/IDP; (b) the QS Survey finding that 65% of prospective Indian students cited financial pressure; (c) coaching industry estimates that approximately 3–4x more students begin preparation than eventually register. These figures should be treated as order-of-magnitude estimates, not precise counts.

5. The Aspiration-Participation Gap: Why Students Drop Out

The QS International Student Survey 2024 found that **65% of prospective Indian students cite financial pressure as a primary concern** when considering study abroad. [7] While this figure encompasses total costs (tuition, living, visa), the examination fee is a unique and particularly acute pain point for the following reasons:

5.1 Irreversibility

Unlike a coaching fee which can sometimes be deferred or paid in instalments, exam registration fees must be paid in full at the time of booking and are largely non-refundable. If a student cancels, they receive only

a partial refund (₹3,500–6,000 for the GRE); if they do not appear on test day, the fee is entirely forfeited. This all-or-nothing structure is particularly harsh for families with limited liquidity.

5.2 The Retake Tax

Most competitive graduate programs seek scores in the 85th–90th percentile or higher. In the 2023–24 GRE cohort, the global average combined score was approximately 305–307 out of 340 — suggesting that a large proportion of test takers do not clear the threshold for their target programs on the first attempt. In India specifically, the 2024 GRE Snapshot Report shows that more than 80% of Indian students who submitted GRE scores were admitted to their top-choice programs, [18] implying the 20% who were not admitted — and many more who did not achieve adequate scores — faced a retake decision. For a middle-class family, the prospect of paying ₹22,000 twice is a significant deterrent.

5.3 Currency Risk

Exam fees are denominated in US dollars. The rupee has depreciated from approximately ₹74/$1 in 2021 to over ₹84/$1 in late 2024, effectively increasing exam costs by 13% for Indian students in three years, without any change in the dollar-denominated fee schedule. Analysts report a 7–11% annual increase in overseas education costs driven partly by currency depreciation. [8]

5.4 Compounding Costs

A student applying to graduate school in the United States typically requires:

Cost Item	Approximate Cost (INR)
GRE registration (1 attempt)	₹22,000
TOEFL registration (1 attempt)	₹16,900
GRE coaching / self-study materials	₹15,000 – ₹50,000
TOEFL coaching / materials	₹8,000 – ₹20,000
Score reporting (4 free; each add'l ~₹1,900)	₹5,700 – ₹11,400
University application fees (5 apps × avg. ₹6,000)	₹30,000
Total (conservative, 1 attempt)	**₹97,600 – ₹1,20,300**
Total (with one retake each)	**₹1,36,500 – ₹1,60,100**

Costs are indicative and based on market rates as of 2025–26. Application fee converted at ₹84/$1.

For a lower-middle-class family with a monthly income of ₹35,000, the conservative total of ₹97,600–1,20,300 represents 2.3–2.9 years' worth of savings — assuming zero other expenditure. This figure makes clear that the barrier is not the exam fee in isolation, but the cumulative cost stack of which the exam fee is the unavoidable, non-negotiable first payment.

> *"A student from a lower-middle-class family hesitates not because they lack ambition or ability, but because they cannot bring themselves to ask their parents to spend what amounts to a month's salary on a test they might fail."*

5.5 Case Study: The 'Takeoff' Financial Barrier

To illustrate the real-world impact, consider a hypothetical scenario of an engineering student from a Tier-2 city aiming for a Master's program abroad. The student requires both a graduate entrance exam (GRE/GMAT) and an English proficiency test (IELTS/TOEFL).

Hypothetical Scenario: The Cumulative Entry Cost

A student attempting the **GRE + IELTS** for the first time faces an immediate outlay of approximately **₹40,000**. Should the student require a single **retake** to meet the competitive cutoffs of top-tier universities, this figure surges to **₹60,000**.

This "takeoff cost" must be paid upfront, in full, and is largely non-refundable. For a family earning ₹35,000 a month, this represents nearly two months of total household earnings spent before the student has even submitted a single university application.

5.6 The 'Big University' Barrier: Oxford, Harvard, and the Multi-Exam Burden

Oxford Style Campus

UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD STYLE

Harvard Style Campus

HARVARD UNIVERSITY STYLE

MIT/Ivy League Style Campus

MIT / IVY LEAGUE STYLE

Big University Barrier Infographic

Figure 5: The "Entry Ticket" Cost Barrier for Elite Universities.

For students aspiring to the world's most prestigious institutions, the financial barrier is not limited to a single test. Most "Big Universities" (Oxford, Harvard, MIT, Stanford, etc.) require a combination of **2 to 3 separate examinations** to even consider an application from an Indian student.

University	Level	Typical Exam Requirements for Indians	Approx. Total Exam Fees
University of Oxford	Postgrad	GRE (Score 320+) + IELTS (7.5) or TOEFL (110)	₹41,000+
Harvard / Stanford	MBA	GMAT (730+) or GRE + TOEFL (109+) or IELTS (7.5)	₹42,000+
MIT / Ivy League	Undergrad	SAT + TOEFL (100+) + AP Exams (Optional but common)	₹27,000 - ₹45,000

The "Entry Ticket" Calculation:

A typical student aiming for these top-tier institutions must budget for the following "Entry Ticket" costs:

- **Exam 1 (Aptitude - GRE/GMAT/SAT):** ₹10,000 – ₹23,500
- **Exam 2 (English - IELTS/TOEFL):** ₹16,900 – ₹19,000
- **Exam 3 (Retake or Subject Test):** ₹15,000 – ₹23,500
- **Score Reporting (to ~5 Universities):** ₹10,000
- **Application Fees (to ~5 Universities):** ₹30,000 – ₹45,000
- **Approximate Total "Entry Ticket" Cost: ₹81,900 – ₹1,21,000**

> **Affordability Crisis: How can a student from a family earning ₹35,000 per month afford a ₹1,00,000 "Entry Ticket"? This amount represents nearly 3 months of total household income spent just to *apply*, with no guarantee of admission or scholarship.**

6. Declining Outbound Student Numbers: Financial Pressure at Scale

The macroeconomic manifestation of these individual-level financial barriers is visible in India's outbound student mobility data, which has declined for three consecutive years — an unprecedented reversal after a decade of sustained growth.

According to data submitted to the Rajya Sabha by Union Minister of State for Education Sukanta Majumdar: Indian students going abroad fell from **9.08 lakh in 2023** to **7.7 lakh in 2024** and further to **6.26 lakh in 2025** — a reduction of nearly 3 lakh students (31%) in just two years. [6]

In parallel, 1.2 million Indian students were enrolled in higher education abroad in 2025 — 5.7% lower than the previous year. [19] The decline has been sharpest in Canada (-41%), the US (-44% F-1 visas in H1 2025), and the UK — historically the top three destinations for Indian students. [20]

While visa policy tightening and geopolitical factors play a role, financial affordability — including the front-loaded cost of standardised examinations — is consistently cited as a primary driver. The Economic Times reports that the rupee's depreciation alone has pushed the cost of overseas study up by 7–11% annually, eroding the purchasing power of middle-class families. [8]

7. Existing Support Mechanisms and Their Limitations

Several government and institutional mechanisms exist to support Indian students seeking overseas education, but their coverage of the examination-fee problem is severely limited.

Scheme / Programme	Administering Body	Benefit	Limitation
National Overseas Scholarship (NOS)	Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment	Full funding (up to $15,400/yr) for SC/ST students with income <₹8L	Only 125 slots per year; restricted to SC/ST; exam fees not explicitly covered [21]
Ambedkar Overseas Vidya Nidhi (Telangana/AP)	State Governments (Telangana, AP)	Up to ₹20 lakh including exam fees	State-specific; not available to students from other states [22]
Ambedkar Interest Subsidy Scheme	Ministry of Social Justice	100% interest subsidy on education loans for OBC/EBC students	Covers tuition loans; does not address front-loaded exam fees at registration time [22]

GRE Fee Reduction Programme (ETS)	ETS	Discounted fee of $100 for demonstrable financial need	Restricted to US citizens and Resident Aliens with a green card; Indian passport holders are categorically ineligible [23]
Ministry of Education External Scholarships	Ministry of Education	Scholarships from foreign governments via cultural exchange programmes	Not specifically targeted at exam fees; competitive and limited in number [24]

The most glaring gap is the ETS Fee Reduction Programme's explicit exclusion of Indian passport holders. A programme that acknowledges financial hardship as a legitimate reason for fee reduction — but restricts eligibility to US residents — is structurally irrelevant to the country that produces the largest or second-largest share of GRE test takers globally. This discriminatory eligibility criterion warrants direct diplomatic and policy engagement by the Government of India.

The NITI Aayog, in its December 2025 report on "Internationalisation of Higher Education in India," acknowledged the need to reduce financial barriers to international test-taking and recommended promoting domestic campuses (such as those in GIFT City, Gujarat) as a cost-reduction mechanism. [25] While this is a constructive long-term direction, it does not address the immediate, pressing issue of examination fees for students who aspire to study at globally ranked foreign universities.

8. Policy Recommendations for the Indian Government

Addressing the financial barrier of standardised examination fees requires a coordinated, multi-stakeholder response. The following recommendations are grounded in existing international precedents, India's domestic financial architecture, and the specific dynamics of the examination market.

Recommendation 1: Establish a National Testing Support Fund (NTSF)

The Government of India should create a dedicated fund (NTSF) under the Ministry of Education to provide a direct

government exam subsidy

for GRE, GMAT, TOEFL, IELTS, and SAT. This fund would serve as a

national testing support fund

to ensure that financial constraints do not impede academic merit. Eligibility should be determined using Annual Household Income (AHI) criteria — students from families earning below ₹8 lakh per annum should receive 100% reimbursement; those earning ₹8–15 lakh should receive 50% reimbursement.

Recommendation 2: Negotiate Bilateral Fee Reduction Agreements with ETS, GMAC, and College Board

India's Ministry of External Affairs and Ministry of Education should formally engage ETS, GMAC, and College Board to negotiate differentiated (Purchasing Power Parity-adjusted) fee structures for Indian test takers, similar to PPP-based pricing used in academic publishing, software, and streaming services. Given India's position as the largest or second-largest market for GRE, GMAT, and IELTS, India has significant negotiating leverage.

Recommendation 3: Mandate EMI / Deferred Payment Options for Indian Test Takers

The Government should, through the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) or SIDBI, work with public sector banks to offer collateral-free, zero-interest micro-loans specifically for examination fee financing. The loan amount (₹15,000–25,000) is small enough to be recovered within 6–12 months of employment.

Recommendation 4: Extend and Universalise the National Overseas Scholarship

The NOS currently supports only 125 students per year — a number utterly disproportionate to the scale of need. The government should: (a) expand the NOS to at least 10,000 slots annually; (b) extend eligibility to OBC and EBC students (not just SC/ST); (c) explicitly include standardised examination fees within the covered expenses. [21]

Recommendation 5: Implement Mandatory Income-Based Fee Waivers

The Government of India should formally request ETS to extend its GRE Fee Reduction Programme to Indian citizens, and should lobby College Board, GMAC, and IELTS administrators to implement globally applicable,

income-based fee waivers

. These waivers should be automated for students who qualify under EWS (Economically Weaker Section) or other national income-verification databases. [23]

Recommendation 6: Create a Centralised Student Exam Registration Portal with Integrated Financial Support

The Ministry of Education should develop a single digital portal where students can register for international examinations, check eligibility for subsidies, and apply for micro-loans. This would reduce information asymmetry and streamline the support-delivery pipeline.

Recommendation 7: Introduce Score-Validity Insurance for Middle-Class Students

In partnership with public sector insurance companies, the government could design a score-validity insurance product: if a student does not achieve a minimum acceptable score on their first attempt, the insurance covers the retake fee.

Recommendation 8: Strategic Partnerships with Global Universities

The Ministry of Education should foster

partnerships with universities

abroad to encourage them to waive application fees or accept scores from lower-cost domestic examinations (like the Indian-administered English proficiency tests) for students who have received the National Testing Support Fund subsidy. These institutional partnerships can significantly reduce the overall financial burden on Indian applicants.

Summary: Four Pillars of Student Support

1. Government Exam Subsidy	Direct reimbursement of registration fees.
2. Income-Based Fee Waivers	Needs-based discounts from exam bodies.
3. National Testing Support Fund	Centralised fund for needs-based aid.
4. Partnerships with Universities	Institutional collaboration for fee waivers.

8.1 A Framework for Government-Exam Body Consultation

Beyond individual policy instruments, the government should establish a standing **India Education Access Commission (IEAC)** — a permanent multi-stakeholder body that includes representatives from the Ministry of Education, Ministry of External Affairs, RBI, exam conducting bodies (ETS India, GMAC India, British Council, IDP India), student advocacy groups, and financial institutions. This Commission should meet biannually to:

- Review fee levels and negotiate PPP-based adjustments
- Audit the uptake and impact of the National Exam Fee Assistance Fund
- Monitor trends in student aspiration and actual participation
- Develop and publicise a unified student support package (subsidies + loans + counselling)
- Report annually to Parliament on access equity in international standardised testing

Exam conducting bodies have commercial incentives to maximise test volumes. A guaranteed, growing Indian market supported by government-backed financial access is in their interest as much as it is in India's. A partnership model, rather than an adversarial one, is both pragmatically sound and more likely to achieve durable results.

9. Conclusion

The high cost of international standardised examinations is not merely an inconvenience — it is a structural barrier that systematically excludes capable, motivated students from India's middle class from the global higher education ecosystem. When a single exam fee consumes more than half a family's monthly income, the decision to sit the test is not a test of academic readiness; it is a test of financial endurance. Many students fail this financial test not because they are not bright enough, but because the system has not been designed with their economic reality in mind.

The consequences are both individual and national. At the individual level, a student who cannot afford to take the GRE is denied the chance to compete for a graduate fellowship at MIT or a research position at Oxford. At the national level, India loses a portion of the human capital it has invested in — the engineers, scientists, economists, and managers whose overseas education would return, in time, as remittances, technology transfers, and diplomatic soft power.

The solutions proposed in this paper are not radical. Needs-based fee subsidies, PPP-adjusted pricing, micro-loans, and expanded scholarships are well-established instruments of education policy. What is radical is the current state of affairs: a country of 1.4 billion people, with the world's largest youth

population, watching its most aspirational students be priced out of global opportunity — one examination fee at a time.

The Indian government has the mandate, the institutional capacity, and increasingly, the diplomatic leverage to change this. The question is whether it will act with the urgency the problem demands.

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